

S. JAIPAL REDDY

URBANISATION **The Next Revolution**

“We have already sanctioned schemes worth Rs 95,385 crore”

First of all, I would like to offer my quintessential outline of the history of urbanisation. Urbanisation represented the dawn of civilisation. But since the time of Harappa and Mohenjodaro to the Taj Mahal, urbanisation was, in a way, stagnant. At the beginning of the 18th century, people living in urban areas at the global level did not even exceed 2 per cent. It was the industrial revolution that sparked off near universal urbanisation. Urbanisation is not something on which you can make a choice.

Now, at the global level more than 50 per cent of the people are living in urban areas. In India, although we have seen frantic urbanisation in recent years, it is modest for us to remind ourselves that only 30 per cent of the people live in urban areas. The progress or development of a nation in the modern world can be judged in terms of the percentage of people living in urban areas. So urbanisation is upon us. Willy-nilly, we have to face it. But before we face it gladly

and readily, we need to be intellectually and emotionally emancipated from the mood of what I might say, country-side conservatism or rural romanticism. It was Socrates who said, “fields and trees teach nothing, but the people in a city do”.

I dare say. More urbanisation is going to take place in India than in all other parts of the world put together. It will not only be the next revolution, it will perhaps be the ultimate revolution in our country. Now, as you know, in our Constitution, urban bodies, urbanisation, is a state subject. And urban development was in a state of benign neglect until Manmohan Singhji through his progressive modern, pioneering vision came up with Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission. When this mission was launched on December 5, 2005, I was just appointed the minister for urban development, and so was asked to handle it. The prime minister said I will not seek money from the World Bank or from any other multilateral agency. We will raise

(From left) Chief Ministers Dhumal, Nishank, Charming, Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar, Union Minister Jaipal Reddy, Delhi Chief Minister Dikshit, Mizoram Minister Zoramangliana, Goa Chief Minister Karat and Rajya Sabha MP Ramachandra Rao

